eighteen, she needed to make her own decisions. She fell silent and waited, hoping Léa would give her blessing to go and meet André.

Léa turned around. “I’m sorry, I’ve got a lot on my mind. There’s no harm in meeting him in the middle of the day in a public square. Just promise me you’ll stay away from any German soldiers.”

Rose nodded and went to embrace her sister. “I promise.”

* * *

The next morning, Rose took special care braiding her hair. She even debated whether to wear it loose. But then she thought how ridiculous it would be to have long strands flowing in her face as she cleaned the school.

What was wrong with her? She didn’t even know what André was like. She’d been too frantic to notice anyone while running away. He might be old enough to be her father. She had no memory of Papa—he’d died a few years after Rose was born—only the old photo of him in uniform before he was sent to fight in the Great War.

She looked down at her hands. This morning, she’d be careful to wear gloves while cleaning the classrooms. Normally, she couldn’t be bothered, but since Savon de Marseille could only be bought on the black market, she had to use a soap with a harsh industrial odor, and she didn’t want the smell to linger on her fingers for the rest of the day.

At noon, she walked along Rue Royale on her way to Place du Martroi, a ripple of excitement coursing through her with each step. The September sun shone bright, softening the crisp air. Brown and russet oak leaves lay scattered on the ground. It was all so strange and new—going to meet a man for the first time, someone who had saved her from prison or worse. And yet she had no idea what he looked like. How would she recognize him? Of course, she didn’t have to. He already knew her.

As Rose reached the square with the statue of Jeanne d’Arc atop her horse, she was struck by how empty and desolate this part of town remained after the German bombing. She remembered the first week of the Occupation when she and Léa stayed in the boardinghouse, too frightened to leave. Eventually, they had to return to work or risk losing their jobs. Léa was a typist in Maître Mallon’s notarial office; Rose cleaned a primary school. Each morning, she woke early, cleaned the school, then returned to